Bhindranwale's growing influence

In 1980, the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD)-Janata Party coalition government in Punjab led by Parkash Singh Badal was dismissed, resulting in fresh elections to the state assembly. In these elections the Congress returned to power. Indira Gandhi appointed Zail Singh's arch rival Darbara Singh as chief minister of Punjab. An insecure Zail Singh, who had become home minster at the Centre, now had to protect his own turf in Punjab while staying on as an active member of the 1 Akbar Road group. In addition to the personal political rivalry between the two Sikh Congress leaders from Punjab, there was a clear clash of ideology as well. Darbara Singh, a member of the old Congress school of thought, was secular in his politics, while Zail Singh not only tolerated communal forces but also compromised with them. He had no qualms about adopting a communal agenda to further both his own and the Congress party's interests in Punjab.

The change in governments at the Centre and in Punjab were followed by a significant increase in violence in the state. Pro-Khalistan activities started getting noticed. According to reports in early April 1980, while visiting village Jandua Bhimshah in tehsil Fazilka, Bhindranwale had announced that 'Bacha' (Gurbachan Singh, head of the Nirankaris) had killed twenty-five persons while he had killed only three. Therefore, he would kill twenty-two Nirankaris more. On 24 April 1980, Gurbachan Singh was shot dead in his house in New Delhi.

Bhindranwale's name figured as one of the suspects in the case. Fearing arrest, he sought refuge in Guru Nanak Niwas (an SGPC-managed guesthouse adjoining the Golden Temple complex) and did not come out till Zail Singh made a statement in parliament that Bhindranwale had nothing to do with Gurbachan Singh's murder. [1] Bhindranwale thereafter announced that Gurbachan Singh's killers deserved to be honoured by the jathedar (head priest) of the Akal Takht. He also said he would himself weigh the killers in gold, if they came to meet him.

In the middle of March 1981, a Sikh educational conference was organized at Chandigarh by Chief Khalsa Diwan, a non-political